

Bill looked over at Andrea. One glance told him the answer. “No, she didn’t,” he said. “But if they’re our bills, I give you my word we’ll pay every one of them, Mrs. Carlisle.”

“Well, I hope you will,” she replied as she headed for the door again. “I want you both to know how disappointed I am that you started out this way. It’s partly my fault, too. Apparently we didn’t teach Andrea some things she needed to know, especially about handling money. We never had very much ourselves and always lived on what little we had. I guess we just assumed our daughter would know how to do the same.” With that she walked over to Andrea, who was crying softly, and hugged her.

“You know I love you—you too, Bill—but you need to grow up. There are responsibilities that come with being an adult. I can’t pay these bills, but I wouldn’t even if I could. You need to accept the consequences of your actions. And you need to be totally honest with your husband,” she said in a solemn tone.

After Andrea’s mother left, Bill sat down to talk with her about the bills. “How much do we really owe, Andrea?” he asked, his voice controlled.

“I don’t know,” she replied. “I haven’t added up all the bills yet. I’m sorry for not telling you before. I didn’t want to bother you during your finals, and then I was afraid to tell you.”

“Andrea, you don’t need to be afraid to tell me anything. But we do need to figure out exactly how much we owe and how we’re going to pay.”

After two hours of poring over the bills that had come in and estimating those that had not been sent yet, Bill came up with a figure of nearly five thousand dollars between the gas card and the bank card.

“What are we going to do?” Andrea asked Bill.

“I don’t know right now,” he answered. “But grad school is out for the fall. And I’m going to need to look for a better job, or we’ll be going further in the hole each month.”